

National Coverage Determination (NCD)

Vagus Nerve Stimulation (VNS)

160.18

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Tracking Information

Publication Number

100-3

Manual Section Number

160.18

Manual Section Title

Vagus Nerve Stimulation (VNS)

Version Number

2

Effective Date of this Version

05/04/2007

Ending Effective Date of this Version

02/15/2019

Implementation Date

07/23/2007

Description Information

Benefit Category

No Benefit Category

Please Note: This may not be an exhaustive list of all applicable Medicare benefit categories for this item or service.

Item/Service Description

A. General

VNS is a pulse generator, similar to a pacemaker, that is surgically implanted under the skin of the left chest and an electrical lead (wire) is connected from the generator to the left vagus nerve. Electrical signals are sent from the battery-powered generator to the vagus nerve via the lead. These signals are in turn sent to the brain. FDA approved **VNS** for treatment of refractory epilepsy in 1997 and for resistant depression in 2005.

Indications and Limitations of Coverage

B. Nationally Covered Indications

Effective for services performed on or after July 1, 1999, **VNS** is reasonable and necessary for patients with medically refractory partial onset seizures for whom surgery is not recommended or for whom surgery has failed.

C. Nationally Non-Covered Indications

Effective for services performed on or after July 1, 1999, **VNS** is not reasonable and necessary for all other types of seizure disorders which are medically refractory and for whom surgery is not recommended or for whom surgery has failed.

Effective for services performed on or after May 4, 2007, **VNS** is not reasonable and necessary for resistant depression. (Information on the national coverage analysis leading to this determination can be found at: http://www.cms.gov/mcd/viewnca.asp?where=index&nca_id=195.)

D. Other

Also see §160, "Electrical Nerve Stimulators."

(This NCD last reviewed May 2007.)

Claims Processing Instructions

TN 1271(Medicare Claims Processing) [↗](#)

Transmittal Information

Transmittal Number

70

Coverage Transmittal Link

<https://www.cms.gov/Regulations-and-Guidance/Guidance/Transmittals/Downloads/R70NCD.pdf> [↗](#)

Revision History

07/2017 - This Change Request (CR) constitutes a maintenance update of International Code of Diseases, Tenth Revision (ICD-10) conversions and other coding updates specific to National Coverage Determinations (NCDs). These NCD coding changes are the result of newly available codes, coding revisions to NCDs released separately, or coding feedback received.

Previous NCD coding changes appear in ICD-10 quarterly updates that can be found at: <https://www.cms.gov/Medicare/Coverage/CoverageGenInfo/ICD10.html>, along with other CRs implementing new policy NCDs. Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent quarterly releases and individual CRs as appropriate. No policy-related changes are included with the ICD-10 quarterly updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. (TN 1875) (CR10184)

11/2016 - This change request (CR) is the 9th maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions and other coding updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). The majority of the NCDs included are a result of feedback received from previous ICD-10 NCD CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, CR9087, CR9252, CR9540, and CR9631. Some are the result of revisions required to other NCD-related CRs released separately.

Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent, quarterly releases as needed. No policy-related changes are included with these updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. (TN 1753) (CR9751)

08/2016 - This change request (CR) is the 9th maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions and other coding updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). The majority of the NCDs included are a result of feedback received from previous ICD-10 NCD CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, CR9087, CR9252, CR9540, and CR9631. Some are the result of revisions required to other NCD-related CRs released separately.

Edits to ICD-10 and other coding updates specific to NCDs will be included in subsequent, quarterly releases as needed. No policy-related changes are included with these updates. Any policy-related changes to NCDs continue to be implemented via the current, long-standing NCD process. (TN 1708) (CR9751)

04/2016 - Transmittal 1630, dated February 26, 2016, is being rescinded and replaced by Transmittal 1658 to (1) remove duplicate spreadsheet NCD210.3, (2) add missing spreadsheet NCD20.33, (3) add B/MAC to requirement 3 at request of WPS/B, (4) rename the spreadsheet titles, and, (5) provide a link to the attached spreadsheets for more efficient ease of reference and accessibility. All other information remains the same. (TN 1658) (CR9540)

12/2015 - This change request (CR) is the 3rd maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions/updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). The majority of the NCDs included are a result of feedback received from previous ICD-10 NCD CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, & CR9087. Some are the result of revisions required to other NCD-related CRs released separately that included ICD-10 coding. Implementation date: 01/04/2016 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1580](#)) (CR9252)

08/2015 - This change request (CR) is the 3rd maintenance update of ICD-10 conversions/updates specific to national coverage determinations (NCDs). The majority of the NCDs included are a result of feedback received from previous ICD-10 NCD CR7818, CR8109, CR8197, CR8691, & CR9087. Some are the result of revisions required to other NCD-related CRs released separately that included ICD-10 coding. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 01/04/2016 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1537](#)) (CR 9252)

05/2014 - CMS translated the information for this policy from ICD-9-CM/PCS to ICD-10-CM/PCS according to HIPAA standard medical data code set requirements and updated any necessary and related coding infrastructure. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 10/06/2014 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1388](#)) ([TN 1388](#)) (CR 8691)

09/2012 - CMS translated the information for this policy from ICD-9-CM/PCS to ICD-10-CM/PCS according to HIPAA standard medical data code set requirements and updated any necessary and related coding infrastructure. These updates do not expand, restrict, or alter existing coverage policy. Implementation date: 01/07/2013 Effective date: 10/1/2015. ([TN 1122](#)) ([TN 1122](#)) (CR 7818)

06/2007 - CMS has determined that VNS is not reasonable and necessary for the treatment of resistant depression. Effective date 05/04/2007. ([TN 70](#)) (CR 5612)

04/1999 - Provided that procedure is safe and effective for patients with medically refractory partial onset seizures for whom surgery is not recommended or has failed. Effective date 07/01/1999. (TN 114) (CR 470)

National Coverage Analyses (NCAs)

This NCD has been or is currently being reviewed under the National Coverage Determination process. The following are existing associations with NCAs, from the National Coverage Analyses database.

- [First reconsideration for Vagus Nerve Stimulation for Treatment of Resistant Depression \(TRD\) \(CAG-00313R\)](#) ↗
- [Second reconsideration for Vagus Nerve Stimulation \(VNS\) for Treatment Resistant Depression \(TRD\) \(CAG-00313R2\)](#) ↗

Additional Information

Other Versions

Title	Version	Effective Between	
Vagus Nerve Stimulation (VNS)	3	02/15/2019 - N/A	View
Vagus Nerve Stimulation (VNS)	2	05/04/2007 - 02/15/2019	You are here
Vagus Nerve Stimulation for Treatment of Seizures	1	07/01/1999 - 05/04/2007	View